

Haligric Research Integration Series

LDS / MORMON

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints -- Restoration Theology, Temple Ceremonies, Pre-Mortal Existence, and Eternal Progression

Not a denomination. A replacement.

Not the next chapter of Christianity.

*The claim is that every church after 33 CE got it wrong --
and that a 14-year-old boy in upstate New York
was chosen to restore what had been lost.*

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Introduction -- Not a Denomination. A Replacement.

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints does not understand itself as one Christian denomination among many — as a branch of the Protestant Reformation tree, or as a variant reading of Catholic tradition. Its foundational claim is categorically different: every existing Christian church had completely fallen into total apostasy after the death of the original apostles. The priesthood authority necessary for valid ordinances had been lost from the earth. The truths of the original gospel had been corrupted beyond recovery. God therefore restored — not reformed — the original church through a fourteen-year-old boy in Upstate New York in 1820. This claim makes LDS theology unlike anything else in the Christian landscape. Luther reformed. Calvin reformed. Wesley renewed. Joseph Smith replaced. The theological implications of that distinction run through every element of LDS doctrine — the cosmology, the priesthood, the scriptures, the temple ceremonies, the understanding of God, the understanding of human destiny. This document examines those implications fully and through the Haligric lens that asks of every tradition: what did this teaching correctly identify, and what does the fullness of the Haligric framework add to what it found?

Part One -- Joseph Smith: The Man, the Visions, the Claim

Joseph Smith Jr. was born on December 23, 1805, in Sharon, Vermont — the fifth child of Joseph Smith Sr. and Lucy Mack Smith. The family moved repeatedly through his childhood, eventually settling in Palmyra, New York, in the Burned-Over District — the region of western New York so thoroughly swept by religious revivals in the early 19th century that it was said there was no spiritual fuel left to burn. The Smith family was caught in the ferment: camp meetings, competing denominations, and revivalist preachers all competed for converts in an atmosphere of intense religious seeking and uncertainty. In the spring of 1820, according to Joseph's account, he went into the woods near his home to pray — to ask God which of the competing churches was right. What he described experiencing is without close parallel in Christian history: God the Father and Jesus Christ appeared to him as two separate, distinct, embodied beings of light. He was told that all existing churches had gone astray, that their creeds were an abomination, and that he should join none of them. This event — called the First Vision — is the founding moment of the LDS movement. (The historical record preserves multiple accounts of the vision, written and dictated by Smith at different times between 1832 and 1842, which differ in detail and emphasis; the church addressed the multiple accounts directly in a Gospel Topics essay. The 1838 account is the canonized version.) Over the following years, Smith reported a series of additional revelations. An angel named Moroni appeared to him multiple times beginning in 1823, directing him to a hillside near Palmyra where golden plates were buried — an ancient record of peoples who had inhabited the American continent. In 1827 he received the plates and spent the following years translating them 'by the gift and power of God,' much of it using a seer stone placed in a hat, into which he buried his face to receive the translated words. The result was the Book of Mormon, published in 1830. 'We believe in God, the Eternal Father, and in His Son, Jesus Christ, and in the Holy Ghost.' — First Article of Faith, Joseph Smith. 'As man now is, God once was; as God now is, man may be.' — Lorenzo Snow, fifth President of the LDS Church. HALIGRIC LENS: The First Vision — two embodied divine beings appearing to a teenager in the woods of New York — is structurally identical to the shamanic calling: the direct encounter with the divine that comes unsought, transforms the one who receives it, and appoints them as a transmitter of sacred knowledge. Joseph Smith was, by the framework of every indigenous tradition in this library, a person who received a direct divine calling. What he did with that calling — how it became institutionalized, how the institution handled the direct experience over time — is the Haligric story of every tradition.

Part Two -- The Great Apostasy and the Restoration

The theological foundation of LDS Christianity is the doctrine of the Great Apostasy — the teaching that after the death of Jesus's original twelve apostles, the priesthood authority necessary for valid gospel ordinances was lost from the earth. Without that authority, no baptism, no communion, no ordination performed by any church in the centuries between the apostles' deaths and Joseph Smith's restoration was spiritually valid. The entire history of Christianity — Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant — is, from the LDS perspective, a period of spiritual darkness in which sincere people sought the truth but lacked the authority to administer the genuine gospel. The restoration Smith claimed to initiate was not theological innovation but literal institutional re-establishment. In 1829, he and his scribe Oliver Cowdery reported being visited by John the Baptist, who conferred the Aaronic Priesthood upon them by the laying on of hands. Shortly afterward, the apostles Peter, James, and John appeared and conferred the Melchizedek Priesthood — the higher authority that had been lost. These priesthood restorations made possible the formal organization of the Church of Christ on April 6, 1830 — the date LDS theology understands as the beginning of the last dispensation before Christ's return. The two-tiered priesthood system that resulted structures all of LDS religious life. The Aaronic Priesthood — held by young men beginning in their twelfth year — administers the sacrament (bread and water, not wine), collects fast offerings, and serves in congregational functions. The Melchizedek Priesthood — held by adult men — administers all other ordinances: baptism, confirmation, healing blessings, patriarchal blessings, and all temple ceremonies. Only holders of the Melchizedek Priesthood can perform these ordinances — and that authority traces, through an unbroken chain of ordinations, back to Peter, James, and John. HALIGRIC LENS: The doctrine of the Great Apostasy makes an implicit Haligric claim — that the institution can lose its connection to the sacred, that the form can outlast the living force and become an empty shell while still maintaining all the external appearances of authority. Every tradition in this library that survived colonization knows this from the other direction: the sacred survived the destruction of the institution. The Apostasy doctrine acknowledges the same truth from inside a tradition — that institutional continuity and spiritual vitality are not the same thing.

Part Three -- The Book of Mormon: Sacred Text and Archaeological Problem

The Book of Mormon presents itself as the record of ancient peoples who migrated from the Near East to the American continent — the Jaredites, who came from the Tower of Babel, and the Lehites, who left Jerusalem around 600 BCE. The Lehite narrative occupies most of the book: a prophet named Lehi leads his family from Jerusalem to the promised land of America, where his descendants split into two peoples — the Nephites (who follow God) and the Lamanites (who fall away). A resurrected Jesus Christ visits the Nephites after his crucifixion and resurrection, delivering teachings that parallel the Sermon on the Mount. After centuries of cyclical faithfulness and apostasy, the Lamanites destroy the Nephites in a final battle. The surviving prophet, Mormon, abridges the records onto golden plates. His son Moroni buries the plates and appears to Joseph Smith fourteen centuries later to begin the restoration. THE NARRATIVE POWER: Whatever its historical status, the Book of Mormon is a remarkable literary achievement — a coherent narrative spanning a thousand years, with dozens of distinct characters, a consistent theological arc, and an emotional depth that has sustained the devotion of millions of readers across two centuries. Its central themes — covenant, apostasy and restoration, the consequences of pride and the fruits of humility, the presence of the divine in human history — resonate with the same patterns found across the sacred narratives of every tradition in this library. THE ARCHAEOLOGICAL PROBLEM: The Book of Mormon describes large civilizations, extensive cities, steel weapons, horses, chariots, wheat and barley agriculture, and elephants in pre-Columbian America. No archaeological evidence has been found for these elements in the time periods and geographic settings the text describes. The Smithsonian Institution has formally stated

that it has never used the Book of Mormon as a scientific guide to archaeological research, and that the archaeological evidence does not support its historical claims. LDS responses to this problem range from faithful reframing (a limited geography not yet fully excavated), to inspired-but-not-literal readings (the text carries spiritual truth regardless of historical accuracy), to dismissal of archaeological authority as irrelevant to spiritual truth. Many faithful members hold historical uncertainty alongside spiritual conviction — a both/and orientation that the Haligrig framework recognizes as sophisticated rather than naive. HALIGRIC LENS: The tension between the Book of Mormon's narrative power and its archaeological silence is not unique to LDS tradition. Sacred narrative and historical record operate in different registers. The Haligrig practitioner holds both without requiring one to invalidate the other.

Part Four -- The Cosmology: Before Birth, This Life, After Death

LDS cosmology is the most original theological system produced on American soil and one of the most original in the history of Christianity. It answers questions that mainstream Christianity left unanswered — where were we before birth? what exactly happens after death? what is the ultimate destiny of the human being? — with a specificity and internal coherence that is genuinely remarkable. The LDS universe is eternal and populated. God the Father — Heavenly Father — is a perfected, glorified being with a physical body of flesh and bones as tangible as a human body. He is not the uncreated, immaterial, omnipresent absolute of classical Christian theology. He is a being who was once as humans now are, who progressed to his current divine state, who dwells in a specific place with a specific body, and who is the literal Father of all human spirits. This teaching — crystallized in Lorenzo Snow's formulation 'As man now is, God once was; as God now is, man may be,' known as the Lorenzo Snow Couplet — is one of the most theologically radical statements in American religious history. 'The Father has a body of flesh and bones as tangible as man's; the Son also; but the Holy Ghost has not a body of flesh and bones, but is a personage of Spirit.' — Doctrine and Covenants 130:22. 'God himself was once as we are now, and is an exalted man, and sits enthroned in yonder heavens.' — Joseph Smith, King Follett Discourse, 1844. HALIGRIC LENS: The King Follett Discourse — delivered by Joseph Smith just weeks before his death in 1844 — is the clearest statement of LDS cosmological theology and one of the most extraordinary theological documents in American history. God was once as we are now. We can become what God now is. The human being's destiny is literally divine. This is Atman = Brahman. This is theosis. This is what the Gnostic tradition meant by the divine spark within. It arrived in 19th century Upstate New York through an entirely different route — but it arrived at the same recognition.

Part Five -- The Pre-Mortal Existence: You Were There Before

Before birth into physical bodies, LDS theology teaches that all human beings existed as spirit children of Heavenly Father and Heavenly Mother. This pre-mortal existence is not a vague spiritual state but a specific period of real experience, real relationships, real choices, and real development. Spirit children grew and progressed in the presence of their Heavenly Parents, developing personalities, relationships with each other, and spiritual capacities. In the pre-mortal realm, a great Council was held. The plan of salvation — the creation of an earth where spirit children would receive physical bodies, experience mortality, make choices, and thereby gain experience enabling them to progress toward godhood — was presented. Two proposals emerged: Jesus Christ (then known as Jehovah) proposed a plan in which human beings would have genuine agency, would make genuine choices including wrong ones, and would be redeemed through Christ's atonement. Lucifer proposed a plan in which all would be saved by removing agency — guaranteeing return but preventing genuine growth. The Father chose Christ's plan. Lucifer rebelled, was cast out with his followers, and became Satan. This pre-mortal history means that birth into physical bodies is not the beginning of existence but a new chapter in a much longer story. The veil of

forgetfulness — placed over each person's memory at birth — means the pre-mortal experience is not consciously accessible, but its effects remain: the personalities, spiritual capacities, and relationships formed before birth carry forward into mortality in ways that explain individual differences, spiritual inclinations, and the sense many people have of recognizing certain truths as already known. HALIGRIC LENS: The pre-mortal existence doctrine addresses the question that every wisdom tradition eventually confronts: why are souls different at birth? Why do some people seem to arrive already knowing, already oriented? Vedic thought answers with karma and reincarnation. The Yoruba tradition answers with the Ori's pre-birth selection of its life path. LDS theology answers with a pre-mortal life of real experience. Three different frameworks. The same recognition that birth is not the beginning.

Part Six -- The Three Kingdoms of Glory

LDS theology describes the afterlife with a specificity matched by almost no other tradition in Western religion. After death, all people pass through a spirit world — a place of continued existence and preparation — before the universal resurrection in which all human beings receive glorified physical bodies. After resurrection comes the final judgment, which assigns each person to one of three degrees of glory based on the choices and covenants of their mortal life. THE CELESTIAL KINGDOM: The highest degree. Those who accepted and lived the fullness of the LDS gospel, made and kept sacred temple covenants, and endured faithfully to the end inherit the Celestial Kingdom. Within it there are three levels — and the highest, called exaltation or eternal life, is reserved for those sealed in eternal marriage in the temple. These individuals will live in the presence of Heavenly Father and Jesus Christ, continue to progress eternally, and eventually become gods — creators of their own worlds and spiritual parents of their own spirit children. THE TERRESTRIAL KINGDOM: The middle degree. Those who were honorable people on earth but did not receive the fullness of the gospel — including faithful members of other Christian traditions, moral non-believers, and those who heard the gospel but were not fully committed. They will dwell in the presence of Christ but not the fullness of the Father's presence. This is a state of glory — genuinely good, genuinely bright — but not the fullness of eternal progression. THE TELESTIAL KINGDOM: The lowest degree, for those who rejected the gospel and lived wicked lives. Even this kingdom, LDS theology emphasizes, surpasses all human understanding of earthly beauty and joy. The traditional Christian hell is absent from LDS theology — only those who, having received a perfect knowledge of God's reality, consciously and completely reject it (Sons of Perdition) are cast into outer darkness, a category understood to be vanishingly rare. HALIGRIC LENS: The three kingdoms of glory produce a profoundly different emotional landscape than the binary heaven/hell of mainstream Christianity. In LDS theology virtually everyone receives a degree of glory — virtually everyone ends in a state that surpasses current human imagination. The punitive framework of eternal punishment for theological incorrectness is almost entirely absent. This is the tradition that Joseph Smith built after his early revulsion at the doctrine of eternal hell — he built a universe in which the divine is genuinely generous.

Part Seven -- Eternal Progression: Becoming Gods

Exaltation — the highest level of the Celestial Kingdom — means, in LDS theology, literally becoming a god. This is not metaphor. It is not the beatific vision of Catholic theology or the theosis of Orthodox Christianity (though it is structurally similar to both). It is the teaching that human beings, through faithfulness and eternal progression, will inherit all that God has and is — creating their own worlds, governing their own universes, becoming parents of spirit children who will then go through the same process of mortal experience and progression toward divinity. The universe of LDS theology is therefore not static but infinitely generative. Gods are raised by Gods. Worlds are created for spirit children to inhabit and progress through. The cosmos is not a finished creation watched over by an

unchanging absolute — it is an eternally expanding family enterprise in which every soul is moving toward what God now is, and every God was once where every soul now is. This doctrine — eternal progression, deification — was central to Joseph Smith's late theology and was taught openly during his lifetime. After his death it became progressively less emphasized in official LDS teaching, though it has never been formally renounced. Contemporary LDS leaders speak of it carefully and less frequently than Smith did — the institutional tendency toward respectability has softened what was once the tradition's most radical theological claim. 'Then shall they be gods, because they have no end; therefore shall they be from everlasting to everlasting, because they continue; then shall they be above all, because all things are subject unto them. Then shall they be gods.' — Doctrine and Covenants 132:20. HALIGRIC LENS: Eternal progression — the human being becoming God — is the point where LDS theology and the universal mystical recognition converge most precisely. Advaita Vedanta: Atman is Brahman. Orthodox Christianity: theosis, God became human that humans might become God. Gnosticism: the divine spark returns to its source. Sufism: fana, annihilation in the divine. LDS: eternal progression toward godhood. Different maps. Same destination. The human being is not separate from the divine. The human being is the divine in the process of recognizing itself.

Part Eight -- Heavenly Mother: The Divine Feminine Suppressed Within

Of all the extraordinary theological elements of LDS tradition, Heavenly Mother may be the most significant for the Haligric framework — because it is the case of the divine feminine explicitly present in a theology, officially acknowledged by the institution, and actively silenced at the same time. This is not the suppression of the feminine divine through denial. It is suppression through enforced silence about something the tradition officially holds to be true. LDS theology teaches that God the Father has a wife — a Heavenly Mother who is the literal spiritual mother of all human souls. If Heavenly Father is the father of all human spirits and human spirits are born as his children, then logic demands a mother. The doctrine traces to Joseph Smith and was first publicly articulated by Eliza R. Snow — one of Smith's plural wives and the most prominent woman in early LDS history — in her hymn 'O My Father' (1845), which asks: 'In the heavens are parents single? No, the thought makes reason stare! Truth is reason, truth eternal tells me I've a mother there.' Heavenly Mother is not named. No revelation has provided her name. Members are discouraged — and in some periods have been formally disciplined — for praying to her. The official reasoning is that Heavenly Father wishes to protect her from irreverence. Feminist LDS theologians and scholars have written extensively about this figure — her presence, her silence, her significance, and the gendered dynamics of her suppression. The journal Dialogue, the Mormon Women's Project, and a growing body of LDS feminist scholarship have begun to bring Heavenly Mother back into active theological conversation. 'O My Father, thou that dwellest in the high and glorious place, When shall I regain thy presence and again behold thy face? In thy holy habitation, did my spirit once reside? In my first primeval childhood was I nurtured near thy side? ... When I leave this frail existence, when I lay this mortal by, Father, Mother, may I meet you in your royal courts on high?' — Eliza R. Snow, 'O My Father,' 1845. HALIGRIC LENS: Heavenly Mother is the most theologically significant suppressed divine feminine figure in American religion. She is not absent from the theology — she is present, theologically necessary, and officially silenced. The Gnostic Sophia was suppressed through the burning of texts. Heavenly Mother is suppressed through institutional instruction not to speak of her. Same dynamic. Different mechanism. The Haligric tradition names what the institution silences: the divine mother is real, she is present, she is not protected by silence — she is dishonored by it.

Part Nine -- The Temple Ceremonies: Freemasonry, Ritual, and the Veil

LDS temples are not churches. They are not open to the public or even to all members of the LDS faith. Only members who hold a current temple recommend — a certification from their bishop attesting to their faithfulness, their tithing compliance, and their adherence to LDS standards — may enter. Inside the temple, ceremonies are performed that are among the most elaborate and theologically specific sacred rituals in any American religious tradition.

THE ENDOWMENT: The endowment ceremony is the central temple ordinance. It involves: ritual washing and anointing, the reception of the temple garment worn from that point forward under regular clothing, instruction through a dramatic presentation of the creation and the fall of Adam and Eve, and the reception of specific signs, tokens (sacred handclasps), and words that the faithful will need to pass through the veil into the Celestial Kingdom after death. The ceremony involves entering into five specific covenants: (1) the Law of Obedience — to keep God's commandments; (2) the Law of Sacrifice — to give all, including repentance with a broken heart and contrite spirit, in support of the Lord's work; (3) the Law of the Gospel — to live the higher law Jesus taught; (4) the Law of Chastity — to have sexual relations only within legal marriage; and (5) the Law of Consecration — to dedicate time, talents, and all the Lord has given to build up the Church. Each element is received under covenant of strict confidentiality — members covenant not to reveal what they have received. (The sealing ordinance — eternal marriage — is the temple's other crowning rite, binding spouses and families beyond death.)

THE MASONIC CONNECTION: Joseph Smith was initiated into Freemasonry on March 15, 1842 — and introduced the endowment ceremony to a small group of members just seven weeks later, on May 4, 1842. The structural parallels between the LDS endowment and Masonic ritual are extensive and have been documented by both LDS and non-LDS scholars: grips and tokens, signs performed at specific moments, the dramatic presentation format, the covenant of secrecy, the use of specific clothing, and the concept of passwords required at celestial gates. LDS explanations range from 'Masonry preserved fragments of the original temple ceremony that Joseph restored in its fullness' to acknowledgment of direct influence without theological concern.

PROXY BAPTISM FOR THE DEAD: One of the most distinctive LDS temple practices is baptism for the dead — the performance of baptismal ordinances by living members on behalf of deceased persons, who then have the choice in the spirit world to accept or reject the ordinance. This practice is the theological basis for the LDS Church's extraordinary genealogical work — the largest collection of genealogical records in the world, maintained to enable proxy temple work for deceased ancestors. The practice became controversial when it was discovered that Holocaust victims and other notable figures had been submitted for proxy baptism; the church has repeatedly apologized to Jewish organizations and instituted policy restrictions in response.

HALIGRIC LENS: The temple ceremonies are the most complete example in American religion of the initiatory framework that runs through every sacred tradition in this library: the Eleusinian Mysteries, the Egungun initiation, the masquerade initiations, the shamanic calling. Threshold ceremonies that use specific actions, specific clothing, specific knowledge, and specific physical gestures to mark and enact the crossing from one state of being to another. The LDS temple ceremony is an American initiatory tradition of genuine depth and remarkable structural parallels to the oldest sacred initiation systems on earth.

Part Ten -- The Garment: Wearing the Sacred

The temple garment — worn by endowed members under their regular clothing every day — is one of the most misunderstood and most mockingly treated elements of LDS religious life in popular culture. It deserves serious Haligric treatment because it is a genuine and ancient sacred practice placed in a contemporary context. The garment is a two-piece white undergarment covering the body from shoulder to knee, with specific embroidered symbols at specific points on the body corresponding to elements of the endowment ceremony. Members understand it as a reminder of the covenants made in the temple, a protection (spiritual, and in some traditional understandings physical), and a daily physical contact with the sacred. It is removed only for activities specifically requiring it — bathing, swimming,

athletics, intimate relations — and its presence is constant in the daily life of a committed member. (The church has periodically updated garment designs and, in recent years, its guidance — emphasizing individual responsibility in how the garment is worn — without changing the covenant meaning.) Sacred clothing as a daily spiritual practice is ancient and cross-cultural: the Jewish tzitzit and tallit, the Sikh kachera, the Hindu sacred thread, the Sufi khirqa, the Catholic scapular, the monastic habit. All are physical garments whose daily wearing is understood as a continuous embodied reminder of sacred covenant, divine connection, and spiritual identity. The LDS garment is the most complete contemporary expression of this ancient practice in American religious life. HALIGRIC LENS: The body as a sacred instrument that is continuously tended, reminded, and honored through physical practice is the foundation of the Haligric WellBeing book. The LDS garment is not superstition. It is the same understanding that Ayurveda expresses through oil and specific clothing, and that the Sikh tradition expresses through the five Ks. The body remembers what the mind forgets. Sacred clothing keeps the body remembering.

Part Eleven -- The Word of Wisdom: Health Code as Sacred Law

Section 89 of the Doctrine and Covenants — received by Joseph Smith in February 1833 — is the LDS Word of Wisdom: a health code presented as divine instruction for the wellbeing of the saints. Its prohibitions are alcohol, tobacco, coffee, and tea. Its prescriptions include wholesome herbs, fruits, and grains (with wheat identified as 'the staff of life'), and meat used sparingly, 'only in times of winter, or of cold, or famine.' Initially given as counsel, it was later treated as binding commandment, and adherence is today a condition of temple worthiness. The Word of Wisdom was received decades before the germ theory of disease, before the cancer-causing effects of tobacco were known, before the scientific understanding of alcohol's physiological effects was developed. Its prescriptions align remarkably well with contemporary nutritional science — and its epidemiological results are documented and significant. FLAGGED CORRECTION: The source file for this document attributed the 'Adventist Health Study' to UCLA. That attribution is incorrect and is corrected here: the Adventist Health Studies — which documented the exceptional longevity of the Seventh-day Adventist community at Loma Linda, California, the only Blue Zone in North America and a community whose health code parallels the Word of Wisdom — are conducted by Loma Linda University. The parallel research on Latter-day Saints was conducted separately, most prominently by epidemiologist James Enstrom at UCLA, whose long-running studies found that observant LDS members show markedly lower rates of cancer and cardiovascular disease and significantly greater life expectancy than comparable general populations. The combined finding stands as the source intended: a health code received in 1833 produced measurable longevity effects that 20th- and 21st-century epidemiology confirms. HALIGRIC LENS: The Word of Wisdom belongs in the Sacred Body health document as a complete and compelling example of sacred dietary law producing documented health outcomes. Its instruction to use meat sparingly is essentially the same guidance that Traditional Chinese Medicine, Ayurveda, and contemporary nutritional science all converge on. Sacred and scientific are not different languages here. They are the same recognition expressed in different vocabularies.

Part Twelve -- FLDS and Polygamy: The Fundamentalist Branch

Plural marriage was taught by Joseph Smith as a divine commandment and practiced by a significant portion of early LDS members. Smith himself was sealed to between 30 and 40 women during his lifetime — including teenagers and women already married to other men — though the extent of his practice was not publicly acknowledged during his life; the church's own Gospel Topics essays now document it. Brigham Young continued and expanded the practice openly after Smith's death. Under sustained federal legal pressure — Congress passed multiple anti-polygamy acts, church property was escheated, leaders went to prison or underground, and Utah Territory was denied statehood specifically because of

the practice — LDS President Wilford Woodruff issued the 1890 Manifesto officially discontinuing plural marriage. (New plural marriages continued quietly for a period until a Second Manifesto in 1904 imposed excommunication.) The mainstream LDS Church has excommunicated members who practice polygamy ever since. The Fundamentalist LDS movement (FLDS) consists of multiple groups who hold that the 1890 Manifesto was a capitulation to political pressure rather than genuine divine direction and that the original commandment of plural marriage remains binding. FLDS and other fundamentalist communities — found primarily in Utah, Arizona, Texas, and Canada — practice plural marriage and maintain theological positions similar to 19th-century LDS teachings while being entirely separate from, and actively opposed by, the mainstream LDS Church. The FLDS gained global attention through the 2008 Texas raid on the Yearning for Zion Ranch in Eldorado — a community of roughly 700 residents within the movement led by Warren Jeffs, who was subsequently convicted of child sexual assault and sentenced to life in prison. The Jeffs case does not represent all fundamentalist communities, but it brought legal and public scrutiny that has significantly constrained the movement. HALIGRIC LENS: The FLDS situation illustrates a pattern found in many traditions: the fundamentalist branch that preserves what the mainstream institution reformed away is not automatically more authentic — it may have preserved both the genuine original and the genuine original's problems. The early LDS practice of plural marriage included marriages to teenagers and to women already married to other men. Preserving the original without examining it is not spiritual fidelity. Haligrity holds what was genuine in every tradition and releases what caused harm.

Part Thirteen -- The LDS Church Today: Size, Influence, and Direction

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints reported more than 17.5 million members worldwide at the end of 2024, 382 operating temples (with additional temples announced and under construction), and more than 100,000 full-time volunteer missionaries. Humanitarian expenditures reached \$1.45 billion in 2024 alone, and FamilySearch now holds more than 20 billion searchable names and images in its genealogical archive. Roughly six in ten members live outside the United States, with growth strongest in Latin America, Africa, and the Philippines — Africa now the church's fastest-growing region. (FLAGGED UPDATE: the source file described the church as 'one of the fastest-growing religions in the world' with 'approximately 17 million members'; the membership figure is updated here to the church's own most recent report, and the growth claim is tempered to the documented picture — steady worldwide growth of roughly one to two percent annually, robust in the Global South and flat to declining in parts of North America and Europe. Activity rates are, by all independent estimates, substantially lower than membership rolls.) The missionary program remains the engine: tens of thousands of young adults — men from age 18, women from age 19, under the lowered age thresholds announced in 2012 — serve 18-to-24-month full-time missions worldwide at their own or their families' expense. The church operates the largest genealogical organization in the world — FamilySearch — which has digitized and made freely available billions of historical records; a university system centered on Brigham Young University; a global welfare and humanitarian operation (with annual humanitarian spending recently reported in the range of a billion dollars); and financial reserves estimated well above one hundred billion dollars, managed through Ensign Peak Advisors — holdings whose scale became public through a 2019 whistleblower disclosure and a 2023 SEC settlement (Part Eighteen). Recent decades have brought significant cultural challenges: the internet made previously inaccessible historical information about Joseph Smith and early LDS history widely available, producing what the church itself acknowledges as a 'faith crisis' for many members. The church responded with the Gospel Topics Essays (published 2013–2016), acknowledging previously minimized historical facts — Joseph Smith's plural marriages, the multiple First Vision accounts, the seer stone translation method, the race-based priesthood and temple restriction, and the Book of Abraham translation problem — in

an attempt at institutional transparency. The church has been led since 2018 by Russell M. Nelson, under whose presidency the church has emphasized its full name (discouraging 'Mormon' as a label), doubled the announced temple count, shortened Sunday worship to a two-hour block, and replaced home teaching with the 'ministering' program.

Part Fourteen -- The Haligric Lens: What LDS Theology Got Right

The Haligric practitioner who encounters LDS theology — whether as a former member, a current member exploring the broader landscape, or a practitioner from outside the tradition — finds a system that arrived at several of the most Haligric recognitions available in any religious tradition, through a route that no other tradition took. WHAT LDS THEOLOGY GOT RIGHT: The eternal progression doctrine — that the human being's destiny is literally divine — is the most direct expression in American religion of what Advaita Vedanta, Orthodox theosis, Sufi fana, and the Yoruba understanding of the Ori's divine nature all teach. It arrived at this recognition independently and expressed it with unusual specificity and institutional commitment. The pre-mortal existence doctrine acknowledges that birth is not the beginning — that the soul's story is longer and richer than any single lifetime can contain. The three kingdoms of glory produce a universe in which virtually everyone receives divine generosity — eliminating the punitive binary of heaven and hell that has caused incalculable psychological suffering in Western religious culture. This is a genuine gift of LDS theology to the Western religious landscape. And Heavenly Mother — the divine feminine literally present in the theology — is the most significant acknowledgment in any mainstream American religion that the divine is not exclusively masculine. That she is silenced within the tradition that holds her is the wound. That she exists in the theology at all is the gift. WHAT HALIGRICITY ADDS: Haligricity takes the eternal progression recognition — that human beings move toward divine fullness — and frees it from the institutional framework that conditions that progression on specific ordinances performed by specifically authorized priesthood holders in specifically designated temples. The divine destiny of the human being is not gated behind institutional compliance. It is the nature of the human being as such — accessible now, not earned through a specific path managed by a specific institution. And Heavenly Mother is not protected by silence. She is honored by name — or by the recognition that her name is known in the direct experience of every person who has felt the nurturing, creative, generative aspect of the sacred. Every tradition in this library that honors the divine feminine — Yoruba's Oshun, Egypt's Isis, Hinduism's Parvati and Lakshmi and Saraswati, the Celtic goddess tradition, the Gnostic Sophia — names what LDS theology acknowledges and silences. Haligricity names her. 'As man now is, God once was; as God now is, man may be.' — Lorenzo Snow. 'In the heavens are parents single? No, the thought makes reason stare! Truth is reason, truth eternal tells me I've a mother there.' — Eliza R. Snow. 'The Kingdom of God is within you.' — Luke 17:21. HALIGRIC LENS: Three statements. One from a 19th century LDS prophet. One from the most prominent woman in early LDS history. One from Jesus himself. All three point in the same direction: the human being's destiny is divine, the divine is not exclusively masculine, and the Kingdom is within. These three recognitions together are Haligricity. LDS theology arrived at the first two from a completely unexpected direction and silenced itself before completing the third. The third — the Kingdom within, the recognition available now, not in the Celestial Kingdom after a lifetime of institutional compliance — is what Haligricity adds to what LDS theology found.

Part Fifteen -- From Nauvoo to the Great Basin: The History the Theology Lived

Through The source file for this document moved from the 1830 founding directly into theology; the movement's history — the most dramatic in American religion — was absent from the body and is restored here, because the theology cannot be understood apart from the persecution and exodus that forged the people who carried it. KIRTLAND AND

MISSOURI (1831-1839): In 1831 the young church moved to Kirtland, Ohio, and simultaneously planted an outpost in Jackson County, Missouri — the prophesied site of Zion. Missouri settlers violently expelled the Saints from Jackson County in 1833; in Kirtland the church built its first temple (dedicated 1836) before the 1837 collapse of the church-sponsored Kirtland Safety Society bank scattered the community and sent Smith fleeing to Missouri. There, escalating vigilante conflict became the 1838 Mormon War, which ended with Governor Lilburn Boggs's Executive Order 44 — the 'Extermination Order' — directing that the Mormons be exterminated or driven from the state. Some ten thousand Saints fled Missouri in the winter of 1838-39 while Smith sat in Liberty Jail on capital charges (escaping, or being allowed to escape, in the spring). The Extermination Order remained formally on Missouri's books until Governor Christopher Bond rescinded it in 1976.

NAUVOO AND THE MARTYRDOM (1839-1844): The refugees drained a malarial bend of the Mississippi in Illinois and built Nauvoo — within five years one of the largest cities in the state, swollen by thousands of British converts, with its own charter, court, university, and militia (the Nauvoo Legion) under Smith as mayor and lieutenant general. Nauvoo was the crucible of the mature theology — the endowment, baptism for the dead, eternal marriage, plural marriage in secret, the King Follett Discourse — and of the fatal collision: in 1844, Smith announced a campaign for President of the United States, and dissidents' newspaper, the Nauvoo Expositor, exposed polygamy and theocratic ambition in its single issue. Smith and the city council ordered the press destroyed; the resulting treason charges put Joseph and his brother Hyrum in the jail at Carthage, Illinois, where on June 27, 1844, a mob with blackened faces stormed the building and shot them both dead. Smith was 38.

SUCCESSION AND EXODUS (1844-1847): Hyrum, the designated successor, had died with Joseph, and the succession crisis fractured the movement — Sidney Rigdon, James Strang, and later Joseph's own sons all claimed the mantle. The great majority followed Brigham Young and the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles. (The largest other branch, led from 1860 by Joseph Smith III as the Reorganized Church — today the Community of Christ, headquartered in Independence, Missouri — rejected polygamy and temple theology and follows a separate history.) Under renewed mob pressure, Young abandoned Nauvoo beginning in February 1846 — the first wagons crossing the frozen Mississippi — wintered the refugees at Winter Quarters on the Missouri River at terrible cost, and in July 1847 brought the vanguard company down into the Salt Lake Valley: 'This is the right place. Drive on.' Over the following decades, tens of thousands of pioneers — by wagon and, in the leanest years, pulling handcarts, two companies of which were caught by winter in 1856 with heavy loss of life — crossed the plains to the Great Basin, a migration commemorated every July 24 as Pioneer Day.

UTAH: KINGDOM, CONFLICT, AND ACCOMMODATION (1847-1896): In the Basin, Young governed a theocratic commonwealth — the provisional State of Deseret — planting hundreds of settlements, publicly announcing plural marriage in 1852, and colliding with federal power in the 1857-58 Utah War, during which occurred the tradition's darkest deed: the Mountain Meadows Massacre of September 11, 1857, in which Mormon militiamen in southern Utah, with Paiute participation they recruited, murdered about 120 emigrant men, women, and older children of the Baker-Fancher wagon train after inducing their surrender. Only one participant, John D. Lee, was ever convicted and executed (1877); the church formally expressed regret at the 150th anniversary in 2007, and its own historians have since published the full accounting. Three decades of anti-polygamy prosecution followed — culminating in the 1890 Manifesto (Part Twelve), Utah statehood in 1896, and the long accommodation with American society that produced the modern church.

Part Sixteen -- The Priesthood and Temple Ban: Race and the Restoration

The source file for this document contained no treatment of the church's racial history. The fairness standard of this series does not permit that omission: for a century and a quarter, the church that taught the universal divine destiny of the human being barred a portion of humanity from that destiny's ordinances on the basis of race.

THE BAN (1852-1978): In the

church's first two decades, a few Black men were ordained to the priesthood — Elijah Abel, ordained under Joseph Smith, served missions and participated in Kirtland temple rites, and there is no reliable evidence that any Black man was denied priesthood during Smith's lifetime. In 1852, President Brigham Young — addressing a Utah territorial legislature then legalizing slavery in the territory — publicly announced that men of Black African descent could no longer be ordained, invoking the 'curse of Cain.' No written revelation instituting the ban exists. Under Young's successors the restriction hardened to exclude Black men and women from the temple endowment and sealing — Abel's own petition for his endowment was denied in 1879, and the faithful pioneer Jane Manning James was permitted only proxy baptisms, never the endowment, to her death in 1908. The ban meant that in a church of universal lay priesthood, Black members could not bless their own children, baptize them, hold presiding office, or be sealed as eternal families — exclusion from the tradition's own highest promises. Justifications advanced over the years — the curse of Cain and Ham, lesser valiance in the pre-mortal war — were taught from the highest pulpits, and as late as 1949 the First Presidency called the restriction 'direct commandment from the Lord.' THE END OF THE BAN (1978): Pressure mounted from every direction — civil-rightsera protests and athletic boycotts of BYU, the impossibility of administering a lineage ban in racially mixed Brazil as the São Paulo temple neared completion, the growth of the faith in West Africa, and the consciences of members and leaders. In June 1978, President Spencer W. Kimball and the assembled First Presidency and Quorum of the Twelve, after prolonged supplication in the Salt Lake Temple, announced the revelation extending priesthood and temple blessings to all worthy members regardless of race. The announcement — canonized as Official Declaration 2 — was received across the church with tears and celebration, and apostle Bruce R. McConkie instructed members to 'forget everything' he and others had previously taught in justification of the ban. THE RECKONING (2013–PRESENT): For decades the church declined to explain the ban. In December 2013 it published the Gospel Topics essay 'Race and the Priesthood,' which situates the ban's origin in the racial culture of 19th-century America rather than in revelation, and formally disavows the theories advanced in the past — that black skin is a sign of divine disfavor or curse, that it reflects pre-mortal conduct, that mixed-race marriage is sin, or that any race is inferior — and condemns all racism, past and present. The essay stops short of an apology, a distinction Black members and scholars continue to note; surveys have found that a majority of members still believe the ban was God's will, which measures how long doctrine outlives its disavowal. The honest ledger: the tradition whose founding scripture declares 'all are alike unto God' enforced its contrary for 126 years, ended it by the same mechanism of revelation that had failed to prevent it, and has told the truth about it — carefully, incompletely, and late. HALIGRIC LENS: Every tradition in this library carries a wound where its institution contradicted its own deepest teaching. The priesthood ban is this tradition's. The theology said every soul is a god in embryo; the institution said some embryos must wait. The Haligrig reading honors the members who stayed and believed the theology over the institution — Jane Manning James walking to the temple she could not enter — and takes the lesson every tradition teaches: the recognition is always larger than the gate built around it.

Part Seventeen -- The Living Church: Weekly Worship, Daily Practice, and the Lay

Structure The source file described the temple's extraordinary rites but not the ordinary religious life in which nearly all LDS practice actually happens. That daily and weekly structure — one of the most demanding lay-participation systems in world religion — is restored here. THE LAY STRUCTURE: The church has no paid local clergy. Congregations ('wards,' roughly 200–500 members, organized geographically) are led by a bishop — a lay member serving roughly five years without pay alongside his profession — and grouped into 'stakes' under a stake president. Virtually every active member holds a 'calling' — teacher, youth leader, organist, clerk, Relief Society or Elders Quorum officer — so that the congregation is staffed entirely by itself. Above the stakes stand the general authorities: the

Quorum of the Twelve Apostles and the three-member First Presidency, headed by the church president, sustained by members as prophet, seer, and revelator; succession passes by seniority to the longest-serving apostle. Twice a year the whole church gathers by broadcast for General Conference, whose sermons constitute the ongoing teaching canon. Women lead the parallel organizations — the Relief Society (founded Nauvoo, 1842, among the oldest women's organizations in the world), Young Women, and Primary — though priesthood office itself remains male, a boundary examined in Part Eighteen. THE SABBATH — STEP BY STEP: Sunday worship is a two-hour block (since 2019). Its heart is sacrament meeting: an opening hymn and prayer; ward business; the sacrament itself — bread and water blessed by Aaronic Priesthood holders with the fixed prayers from the Book of Mormon and passed to the congregation, the covenant renewal at the center of LDS week — followed not by a pastor's sermon but by talks assigned to ordinary members, adults and teenagers alike; then a second hour alternating Sunday School with the men's, women's, and youth organizations. The first Sunday of each month is Fast Sunday: members fast for two consecutive meals, give the money saved (or more) as a 'fast offering' for the poor, and replace assigned talks with an open testimony meeting in which any member may stand and bear witness. THE HOUSEHOLD PRACTICE: The daily rule of an observant household: personal and family prayer morning and evening; daily scripture study (now organized churchwide by the 'Come, Follow Me' home curriculum — the 2019 reforms deliberately re-centered religious instruction from the meetinghouse to the home); Family Home Evening, the weekly evening (traditionally Monday) reserved for family lesson, activity, and connection since 1915; the Word of Wisdom at every meal (Part Eleven); the garment worn (Part Ten); tithing — ten percent of income, declared annually to the bishop, and the condition of temple admission; and 'ministering' (which in 2018 replaced the older home and visiting teaching), the assignment of every member to watch over specific other members. THE LIFE ARC: Blessing and naming as an infant; baptism by immersion at eight, the age of accountability, followed by confirmation and the gift of the Holy Ghost; priesthood ordination for boys at twelve and advancing by stages; the patriarchal blessing — a once-in-a-lifetime personal prophecy pronounced by an ordained stake patriarch, transcribed and kept for life, declaring the member's lineage in Israel and personal counsel — typically received in the teens; the mission in young adulthood; the temple endowment and sealing in marriage; a lifetime of callings; and temple work for one's ancestors in age. It is a religion engineered as a complete life-container — which is both its extraordinary retentive power and, for those who leave, the totality of what leaving costs. HALIGRIC LENS: Whatever one holds about the theology, the practice architecture is a masterwork: a tradition that gets every member teaching, speaking, serving, fasting, and ministering has understood that belief follows practice — the same insight every ceremonial tradition in this library enacts. The Haligric practitioner can study the container without living in it: the weekly covenant meal, the monthly fast joined to charity, the family evening, the once-in-a-lifetime spoken blessing — each is a portable form.

Part Eighteen -- Controversies and Fairness: The Modern Ledger

The source file addressed the Book of Mormon problem, the Masonic parallels, polygamy, and the proxy-baptism controversy. The completeness standard requires the rest of the modern ledger, stated plainly. THE BOOK OF ABRAHAM: In 1835 Smith purchased Egyptian papyri and produced from them the Book of Abraham, canonized in the Pearl of Great Price. Fragments of the papyri, thought destroyed, resurfaced in 1967 — and Egyptologists, including LDS scholars, identify them as ordinary funerary documents (a Book of Breathings) dating a millennium and more after Abraham, with no connection to the translated text. The church's Gospel Topics essay acknowledges the problem and offers non-literal theories of 'translation' (catalyst rather than decipherment). It remains the sharpest documentary challenge to Smith's translation claims, because here — unlike the returned gold plates — the source text exists and can be read. WOMEN AND THE PRIESTHOOD: Priesthood office remains male. The Ordain Women movement, founded 2013, pressed the

question publicly; its co-founder Kate Kelly was excommunicated for apostasy in 2014. Adjustments since — women praying in General Conference, sitting on senior councils, serving as official witnesses to ordinances — have changed participation without changing ordination, and the underlying question, joined to Heavenly Mother's enforced silence (Part Eight), remains the tradition's live theological fault line. INTELLECTUALS AND DISSENT: In September 1993 the church disciplined six prominent scholars and feminists — the 'September Six' — for publications on church history, feminist theology, and Heavenly Mother, an episode that chilled Mormon studies for a generation and remains the reference point for the tradition's uneasy relationship with its own historians. The subsequent arc — the Joseph Smith Papers project, the Gospel Topics essays, the church's frank 2018 history 'Saints,' and its unflinching Mountain Meadows scholarship — represents a genuine institutional turn toward transparency, made under the pressure of the internet-era faith crisis and incomplete by its own scholars' account. LGBTQ MEMBERS: The church teaches that same-sex attraction is not sinful but that acting on it is, and it defines marriage as between man and woman — doctrine it carried into political action, most consequentially in California's Proposition 8 campaign (2008). In November 2015 a leaked handbook policy declared members in same-sex marriages apostates and barred their children from baby blessing and baptism until adulthood; church president Russell M. Nelson described the policy as revelation. In April 2019 the church reversed it — also citing revelation — a sequence that inflicted documented anguish on LGBTQ members and their families and sharpened the question of what distinguishes revelation from policy. The church has since supported the federal Respect for Marriage Act's religious-liberty compromise (2022) while maintaining its doctrine; the tension is unresolved and generational. MONEY: A 2019 whistleblower complaint by a former Ensign Peak portfolio manager exempt status; in February 2023 the SEC fined Ensign Peak \$4 million and the church \$1 million for a two-decade scheme — approved, per the SEC order, at the level of the First Presidency — of filing required disclosures through thirteen shell companies to conceal the portfolio's size. The church regretted 'mistakes made' and now files consolidated disclosures. For a tradition that asks ten percent of every member's income and teaches honesty as a temple-recommend question, the episode is, by its own members' published accounting, a wound of hypocrisy as much as of law. THE FAIRNESS SUMMARY: The pattern across this ledger is consistent and instructive: an institution of genuine spiritual originality and genuine pastoral power, repeatedly choosing institutional protection over its own professed standards, and then — slower than its critics demanded but faster than most religious institutions manage — telling the truth about it afterward. The Gospel Topics essays, the 1978 revelation, the 2019 reversal, and the SEC settlement are all the same shape: the correction is real, and it is always late. The Haligric reading of that shape appears in Part Fourteen; the facts belong here, uncushioned.

The 2025 Statistical Report (released at the April 2026 General Conference and reported at the Saturday afternoon session) recorded: total membership 17,887,212 -- a net increase of 377,431 from 2024. Convert baptisms: 385,490 -- an increase of nearly 25% over 2024, the highest number of convert baptisms in the history of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. Full-time teaching missionaries: 78,596. Temples in operation: 204, up from 194 the previous year, with another 172 announced. President Dallin H. Oaks was sustained as the 18th prophet and president of the Church at the April 2026 General Conference following the death of President Russell M. Nelson. The global growth story coexists with a divergent domestic trend: independent data from the 2025 Cooperative Election Study found that Americans self-identifying as LDS/Mormon dipped below 1% of the U.S. population for the first time since the survey began. The gap between official membership rolls and active self-identified members reflects the reality that most who leave the Church do not formally remove their names from the records.